

Instead of regrouping and recalibrating strategy to take on the common opponent, BJP leaders seem more intent on pulling each other and the party down. It was just the perfect setting for the RSS to step in and Jaswant was easy prey. Though one of the party's seniormost leaders, he was never a member of the RSS. "Jaswant Singh was a BJP minister and office-bearer, but he was never a BJP leader. He carried with him the aura of a leader without the acceptability of the masses," said a source in the party. As one who never identified with the core of the BJP, Jaswant had little connect with party workers. The BJP's swiftness in dealing with him is seen as an indication of the renewed dominant role that the parent organisation intends to have in the affairs of the party.

On the eve of the Chintan Baithak, RSS supremo Mohan Bhagwat had sent a message to the party leadership stating that his advice to the swayamsevak in the BJP was to be "sound and articulate" about their ideology. A committee headed by Bal Apte set up to look into the Lok Sabha defeat had come up with talking points for the Shimla session and had identified the drift away from the party ideology as one of the reasons for the subsequent electoral drubbing.

If Jaswant's praise of Jinnah was not galling enough, the implicit criticism of BJP icon Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel was the decider. The day after Jaswant's book was released, Rajnath issued a curt press release attacking Jinnah and praising Patel. "Sardar Patel played a historic role in the unification and consolidation of India... entire nation remains indebted and proud (of him)," he said. Jaswant's blaming of Patel for Partition had a direct connection in the Iron Man's home state, Gujarat, where the BJP and Chief Minister Narendra Modi have effectively used the slogan of Gujarati pride, which is intertwined with the alleged injustice done to the Sardar by the Congress and the Nehru dynasty, to firm up the saffron party politically. Jaswant's continuance in the BJP would have given an effective handle to local Congress leaders.

Jaswant's Jinnah also clearly rubbed Shiv Sena supremo Bal Thackeray the wrong way, with the Maharashtra tiger seeking to know the source of such misplaced notions that prompted Advani and Jaswant to call Jinnah a hero and a secularist. In the state where the BJP-Shiv Sena alliance has an uphill task trying to oust the Congress-NCP combine, the electorate is not expected to forgive such ideologically muddled statements by senior BJP leaders. The fact that the Gujarat Government banned Jaswant's book within a few hours of his expulsion from the BJP makes it evident that Modi along with the Shiv Sena boss had played a crucial role in his eviction from the party.

With the BJP tottering between minor revolts to full blown rebellions post the Lok Sabha elections, the Chintan Baithak was expected to be a fiery affair. In June, a month after the elections, Jaswant had writ-

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If the RSS finally takes over the reins once again, leaders who walked the road laid by the parent organisation, quietly and without flamboyance, are expected to get its full backing. And they will be the chosen ones who will have a meaningful role in trying to turn the party's fortunes in the years to come.

